

knife giveaway, the vast amount of premium refund offers available would boggle the mind of any 1880s salesman. By the 1980s, it was easy for me to stock a Christmas gift cupboard with free crayons, balls, hats, T-shirts, towels, and stuffed animals, not to mention all the cash-back offers that could easily add up to almost 100 dollars a month.

A typical refund back then might simply request four UPCs or ten wrappers, of which the avid refunder would already have in their files, waiting for just such an offer. Before the advent of UPC codes, manufacturers might ask for a net weight statement for one offer and a boxtop for another, so the savvy refunder saved the entire package from the products they bought. Cash register tapes were rarely needed, except for some of the more lucrative offers like money back on a liquor purchase or car tires. Manufacturers counted on a certain amount of “slippage” with these offers, using the special offer to motivate the customer to purchase the product, knowing that a good percentage of consumers would inevitably forget to send for the refund. Hardcore refunders, however, didn’t let anything slip by them. If it was free, they sent for it, even if it was a cat toy and they had no pets.

Mail-in rebates, or instant rebates, are still used as a promotional tool, especially for electronics and other big-ticket items. They’re offered either by the retailer or the manufacturer. Now, many of the forms are printed right at the cash register at the time of purchase, or just like in the good old days, a separate form is required to mail in for the refund. Most offers are handled under contract by a clearinghouse that specializes in processing rebates and contest entries.